

A DESPERATE SAVE Penalty box action in a Mohun Bagan SG vs FC Goa ISL match in Kolkata, Mar. 8, 2025

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THE VIDEO, STARK AND SPARE, DROPPED SUDDENLY. On January 2, senior members of the Indian national football team, among them Sunil Chhetri, Gurpreet Singh Sandhu, Sandesh Jhingan and Brandon Fernandes, did something desperate—they made a direct appeal to FIFA, football's global governing body, to ensure that the delayed Indian Super League (ISL) tournament was staged. One line from the video stood out: "We just want to play football. Uncertainty is killing careers." Sandhu said, "We should be playing competitive football in the ISL. Instead we are driven by fear and desperation." They had good reason, for the ISL, Indian football's premier competition, is that rare tournament that pays well.

Anyone vouching for Indian football's rude health after taking in the delirious response to Lionel Messi during his GOAT India tour would be mistaken, for the organisational edifice of the beautiful game in India is in a state of decay. Beyond the spotlight on Messi, Indian footballers and coaches were training alone, negotiating pay cuts or waiting months for their salaries.

Consider the outward signs of the rot—the ISL could not be organised on time (usually September); the I-League, the second tier that sustains the broader footballing pyramid, limped along without a sponsor; and the All India Football Federation (AIFF), the top governing body of the game, is mired in court cases and institutional paralysis. Inevitably, those worst hit are the players, coaches and support staff whose careers are on the line. Expectedly, off-field problems have grievously affected onfield form. India now sits outside Asia's top tier in football, having slid to 141 in the FIFA rankings and failing to qualify for even the AFC Asian Cup, the continent's top tournament.

THE ASIAN FOOTBALL CONFEDERATION REQUIRES CLUBS TO PLAY AT LEAST 24 MATCHES FOR A DIRECT ENTRY TO THE AFC CHAMPIONS LEAGUE. WITH THE TRUNCATED ISL, INDIAN CLUBS WILL MANAGE ONLY 13

On January 6, four days after the players' appeal, Union sports minister Mansukh Mandaviya announced a mid-February kick-off for the ISL, assuring the Centre's backing. Accordingly, a stripped-down version of the tournament kicked off on February 14 and will go on till May.

AN INSUPERABLE LEAGUE

The immediate trigger for the delay of the ISL was the expiry of AIFF's Master Rights Agreement with Football Sports Development Limited (FSDL)—the Reliance-backed entity that held commercial and operational control of the ISL—in December 2025. For the first time since its inception in 2013, the ISL had no central operator. Absurdly, the federation—the owner of the ISL—had lined up no successor.

The AIFF says it had tried to save the situation. "We wrote to the FSDL multiple times between September 2024 and March 2025 and received no response. When discussions began, the demands were not something the federation could accept. In April, the Supreme Court directed that no new developments should happen until the AIFF constitution was finalised," says an AIFF source.

The legal wrangles the AIFF is caught in has contributed to the delays. It has a long trail. Petitions dating back to 2017 challenged AIFF governance on transparency, term limits and elections. In May 2022, the SC installed a committee of administrators to run Indian football, triggering a FIFA suspension in August that was lifted a few days later after elections to the AIFF were held under judicial supervision. A final SC verdict in September 2025 aimed to end the protracted litigation and instability by approving a new constitution for the AIFF, but placed oversight on key commercial decisions, including ISL tendering. The court may have done its best, but years of vicious infighting amongst the AIFF top brass hampered smooth functioning, caused paralysis in governance and did irreparable harm to the game in India.

As 2025 wore on and it became clear that the FSDL wasn't interested in renewing its contract, the AIFF constituted a three-member committee—